Muting Durably Reduces Engagement with Untrustworthy Online Sources; Media Literacy Doesn't

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RESEARCH QUESTION

How can we *durably* improve information consumption behaviors of users with low-quality information diets?

Tested a **cognitive** lever (teaching to avoid untrustworthy sources) against an **environmental** one (removing such sources).

STUDY DESIGN

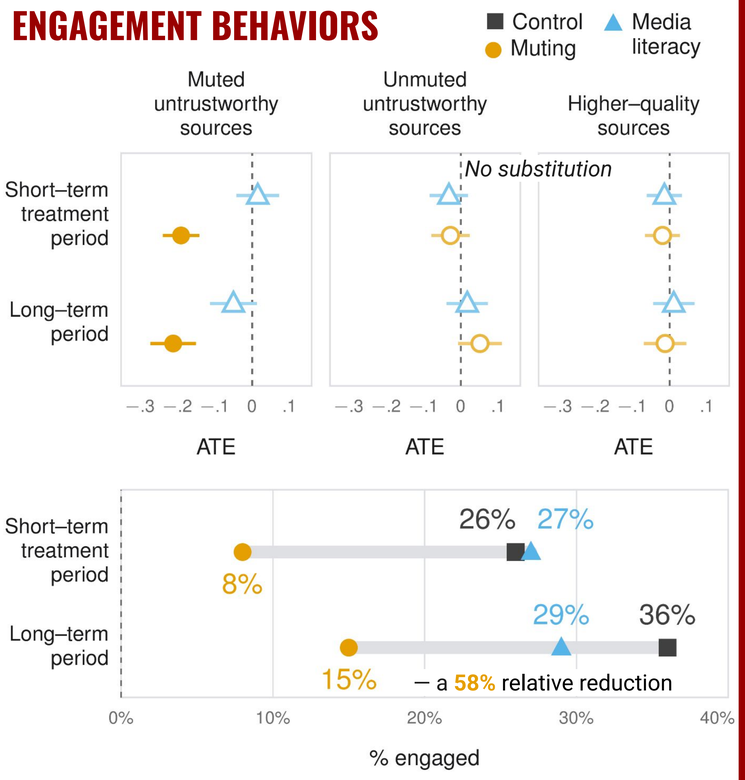
Three-arm RCT on X (N=1,210)

- ❏ CONTROL
- ❏ MUTING: A random subset (n=304) of untrustworthy sources muted, with incentives to stay muted for four weeks
- ❏ MEDIA LITERACY: Tips for identifying false content, plus three weekly reminders

Outcomes

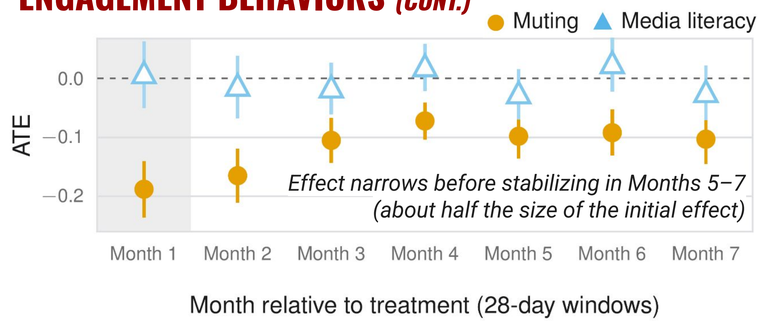
- ❏ Engagement behaviors
- ❏ Sharing and accuracy discernment
- ❏ Trust and willingness-to-accept

ENGAGEMENT BEHAVIORS

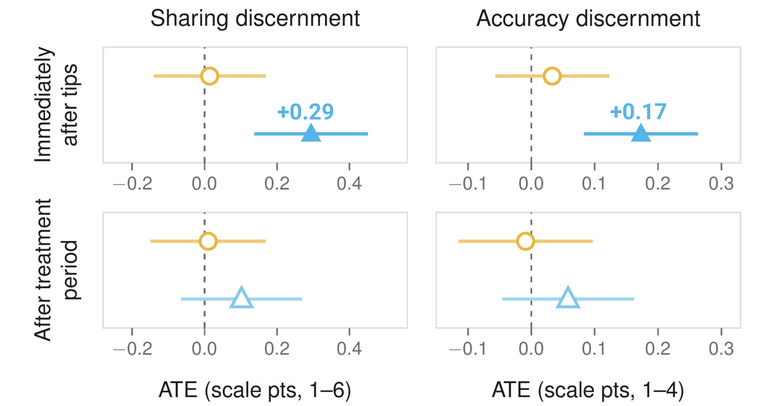


Muting reduced engagement with targeted sources, with effects persisting for more than six months after the incentive period ended. **Media literacy tips** temporarily improved discernment, without any effects on engagements.

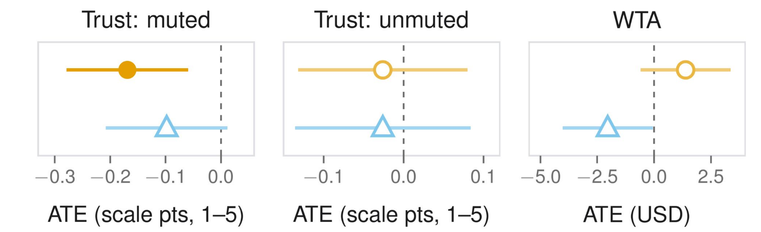
ENGAGEMENT BEHAVIORS *(CONT.)*



INFORMATION DISCERNMENT



TRUST & DEMAND (WTA)



IMPLICATIONS

- ❏ For vulnerable users, consumption of untrustworthy information may depend more on their **visibility** than on a lack of discernment or demand for the content they provide.
- ❏ **Muting** effectively created a new **default**: A one-time change to the information environment can produce durable changes in engagement behaviors without continued incentives or enforcement.